

DILIP
KAPUR

60, LEATHER GOODS MANUFACTURER
FOUNDER, H I D E S I G N
TURNOVER IN 1978 Rs 1 crore
CURRENT TURNOVER Rs 300 crore

FOLLOW THE LEATHER

From the word go, Dilip Kapur had little going for him as an entrepreneur. To begin with, Kapur was brought up in a culture of renunciation and simplicity from the time he was four, when his father sold his leather business in Delhi to join the Auroville ashram in Puducherry. The influence of the ashram was strengthened by his college days in the US in the 1960s, when the educated youth stood against all things American. Ironically, though, 56 years after his father sold his leather business, Kapur is head of a global company called Hidesign.

What makes Kapur's journey fascinating is not his business acumen, but the lack of it. Nothing in his past shows the signs of Kapur metamorphosing into a wealth creator. Long before green became cool, Kapur chose to go the eco-friendly way by using vegetable dyes to tan products so they derived a natural and raw look. Says Kapur: "Hidesign is driven by the passion of a multi-cultural design-oriented team."

But all this was not a deliberate strategy. Given that Kapur never saw his father do a job that yielded financial returns, his attitude to life was significantly different from that of any other young professional. Explains Kapur: "We didn't have a normal life at the ashram so business was farthest from my mind. But the free education system there allowed me to experiment." It was an alternative reality of sorts that Kapur was deeply rooted in at one level and yet desperately wanted to break away from at another. So at the age of 14, Kapur applied for a scholarship to Andover Prep School, in Massachusetts, US, and got a full scholarship. "The second biggest influence of my life came in the US, where I participated in the students' movement." It was the '60s and rebellion was in the air. After completing his PhD in International Affairs at the University of Denver, Kapur

returned to Puducherry. But a PhD was not the only thing he carried back to India. He had also gained experience in a leather bag factory to earn some extra dollars.

The hobby stayed with Kapur because his duties at Auroville didn't take much of his time. Whenever his friends came calling, they carried his bags back. As orders kept coming, Kapur kept making bags at his home, now a boutique hotel, Promenade. Then Lowell Harder, a London-based architect, visited Kapur at the request of her hippy cousin who had picked up one of Kapur's bags earlier. Harder saw a business opportunity in his bags. She began selling them at Camden, a popular flea market in London. The bags were a big hit. Harder then began to actively scout for large buyers and department stores.

The turning point came in 1990, when one of the regular customers of Hidesign turned out to be a buyer for the UK departmental store, John Lewis. After hitting the high streets, there was no looking back for Kapur as Hidesign came to enjoy pride of place at London's swish Selfridges and Debenhams. By the turn of the

century, it was selling in Russia and the US, but its presence in India was negligible. Says Kapur: "I was not sure if I had customers in India since our bags were far more expensive than what was available here." In 2000, however, Kapur set up his first store in Connaught Place,

Delhi. The store was a hit. By end 2004, Hidesign had emerged as the leading Indian leather brand. Last year, India logged the maximum sales. By 2006, Louis Vuitton had come calling. Ask him how the journey has been from protesting against all things materialistic to promoting a Rs 300-crore business, and he says, "Walking the path of idealism is difficult. Making bags was easier and I took the easier path in life."

by Malini Bhupta

LOUIS VUITTON
PICKED UP A STAKE IN
HIDESIGN RECENTLY.

AND NOW KAPUR IS
HELPING IT SET UP
BASE IN INDIA. HE
HAD EARLIER
REFUSED TO MEET
THEM THINKING
THAT THEY
WANTED HIM TO
MANUFACTURE
FOR THEM.

Rising prices do not mean falling hopes.
Not after talking to us.

Perhaps it's time you had a *Gold Conversation*. With Citigold Global Banking, you can draw upon our unparalleled investment expertise and product offerings to create a geographically diverse portfolio. For an in-depth discussion on our global banking services, simply contact your Citigold Relationship Manager.

Just SMS 'Global' to 52484 or visit us at www.citigold.info

Information. Insight.

Citigold

Citi never sleeps

citibank

Gold Conversation, Citi Never Sleeps and Arc Design are service marks of Citigroup Inc. Citigold and Citibank are registered service marks of Citigroup Inc. or Citibank N.A. Terms and Conditions apply. For detailed terms and conditions, please refer to www.citibank.com/india. Publicis Ambience/Citigold/08-11-0224